

Walk After Your New Nature

Romans 7 is an unregenerated man, and Paul is particularly talking to the Jew. He is talking about a spiritually dead man who received the law of the Ten Commandments, but because he was spiritually dead, he could not keep it.

Paul speaks hypothetically for every Jew when he says:

"I had not known sin, except the law had said, Thou shalt not covet."

When the law said, "Thou shalt not covet," it woke up all manner of concupiscence in him. Without the law, sin was dead. A spiritually dead man does not know he is spiritually dead until the law comes along and tells him to stop being what he is. That is when he finds out he cannot.

Then, in Romans 8, there is a change of covenants. At the end of Romans 7 he cries:

"Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

Then he answers his own question:

"I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord."

So Romans 8 begins:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

Every time Paul uses the terminology "not after the flesh, but after the Spirit" in Romans 8, he is moving between Romans 7 and Romans 8. "After the flesh" points to the spiritually dead man under the law who could not keep it. "After the Spirit" points to the born-again new nature that we received, the nature that freed us from sin.

For years, most people have preached "after the Spirit" as if Paul were only talking about walking after the Holy Spirit. The word is capitalized in the King James, but the original Greek word for spirit is the same word whether it is referring to the spirit of man or the Spirit of God. The translator has to decide by the way it is used in the sentence.

The Holy Spirit is introduced later in Romans 8 as the One who comes to help our weaknesses and enforce the new nature. But outside that new nature, He has nothing to work with. In this passage, "after the Spirit" is talking about walking after the new nature, the new creation you have become, which has set you free from sin.

Romans 8:1-2 says:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit. For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

The law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus made me free from that law of sin and death.

Romans 8:3 says:

"For what the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh, God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh."

What could the law not do? It could not make a spiritually dead man keep the nature of God. Paul said, "The good that I would do, I could not. The evil that I would not do, I ended up doing."

God sent His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, and by sacrifice for sin He condemned sin in the flesh. How did He do that? We received a new nature through the law of the Spirit of life, and that new nature freed us from the power of sin. Sin was condemned in the flesh, meaning we do not have to walk after it anymore.

When Paul says sin shall not have dominion over you, that includes sin and all its friends: sickness, poverty, depression, and the things that try to reign over you. They have lost dominion. They do not have the power to reign over you anymore, and that new nature in you is what caused it.

The Holy Spirit has come to help our weaknesses. He supplies us with a prayer language and brings the power of God for miracles. But it was your new nature that freed you from sin. If the Holy Spirit could have freed anyone from sin without the new birth, He would have freed all the Old Testament saints in Abraham's bosom. Before Jesus rose from the dead, there was no law of the Spirit of life, so He could not do that work in them.

When the Holy Spirit regenerated my spirit, that happened to my spirit. The Holy Spirit is one Person, the third Person of the Godhead. I am another person, a born-again man. He created the new nature in me, but the new nature happened to me, and that is what set me free.

Jesus walked thirty years with the same nature in His human spirit that you now have in yours. Then He died spiritually and was raised again. But for thirty years He walked with the life of God in Him, the same life now in you, and He did not sin.

At thirty years old, Jesus received the baptism of the Holy Spirit and began to minister in power. The baptism of the Holy Spirit supplied the power. Because the Holy Spirit brought that language with Him, He prays for our infirmities and weaknesses as we yield ourselves to Him. He strengthens us through that new nature.

But one more time: it was the new nature that set you free from sin and caused sin to lose its dominion over you. The new nature is what the Holy Spirit gets behind and enforces in your life when you want to be free.

If you start justifying sin, the Holy Ghost cannot do anything. You take away His ability to work for you.

Someone says, "The devil made me do it."

As long as you give the devil more power than your sinless new nature and the Holy Ghost's ability to enforce it, the devil will walk over you. You say, "He made me do it," and the Holy Ghost is standing there saying, "He just said the devil has more power than I do."

Someone else says, "My circumstances are more powerful than me."

No, they are not. Sin has lost its dominion.

Romans 8:3-4 says:

"For what the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh,
God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh,
and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh:
That the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us,
who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

When Paul talks about the righteousness of the law, he is not talking about sacrifices and killing animals. He is talking about the right standing of the law: "Thou shalt not covet," "Thou shalt not bear false witness," "Thou shalt have no other gods before Me."

That right standing of the law takes a new nature to fulfill, and it can now be fulfilled in us who walk not after the unregenerated flesh, but after the new nature we have received.

Every time I teach this, I get so free. Hallelujah.

Romans 8:5 says:

"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit."

The unregenerated man has the law and cannot keep it. Sin rises up and forces his mind into subjection. Paul said, "That which I would not do, I end up doing. That which I would do, I end up not doing."

They that are after the flesh mind the things of the flesh because their mind is brought under the law of sin and death. But they that are after the spirit, those who walk after the new nature, especially when it is being enforced by the Holy Ghost, have their mind brought under subjection to the things of the spirit.

You are not forced into sin anymore. You do not have to sin anymore. Sin lost its dominion.

Romans 8:6-9 says:

"For to be carnally minded is death;
but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.
Because the carnal mind is enmity against God:
for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be.
So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God.
But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit,
if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you.
Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."

Paul is still giving positional truth. You may get up in the morning, cut yourself, and feel very much like you are in the flesh. But Paul is dividing Romans 7 and Romans 8 like a finely tuned surgeon, arguing as a lawyer between the two covenants to show why you were set free.

You are not in the flesh, but in the spirit. What qualifies you to be in the spirit? The spirit of God dwells in you.

Which spirit? He qualifies it in the last half of verse 9:

"Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."

The Spirit of Christ is not the Holy Ghost, and it is not Jesus' own human spirit baptizing everybody. As God had life within Himself, He gave to the Son to have life within Himself. When you were born again, the Son gave you to have life within yourself.

You did not have Adam's actual human spirit, but you inherited the spirit of Adam, spiritual death. You do not have that anymore. You have the spirit that is of God, that you might know the things freely given to you by God, because you have been born again.

By the transgression of one man, Adam, sin entered the world, and death by sin. The whole human race inherited spiritual death from him. You did not have Adam's human spirit; you had your own. Now you have been born of the last Adam. You do not have Jesus' spirit in His humanity; you have the Spirit of Christ, just like you used to have the spirit of the first man, Adam.

It is your own spirit, but it has been born again, quickened from death to life. You are no longer in the flesh, an unregenerated man whose mind is under the control of sin and can walk after nothing but sin. You have been born again, and your mind can now come under subjection to your new nature.

In our Christian language, we say, "He was really in the flesh," meaning something had more influence on him than Christ did. There is a common way we talk about getting in the flesh or getting in the spirit.

Sometimes when you are in the flesh, it does not feel as if that new nature is much stronger than the flesh. But until you choose to believe the Word at surface value, you will not get very far. Your feelings do not mean two cents to God.

You may be all messed up, but the first thing you must accept is that you are free. Until you accept that you are free, the Holy Ghost has nothing to work with. He wants to enforce your new nature and give you strength to come out of those things.

That power works inward as well as outward, but you have to give Him something to work with.

This is how grace works. Suppose you are addicted to something. Smoking is an example, but this applies to more than smoking. Some things alter your mind and loosen your hold against the devil: drugs, alcohol, marijuana, or anything that causes you to lose grip on reality. Those things open a door for the devil to take you places you do not want to go.

Nicotine is a sedative. Sometimes a deep problem begins to surface, and it is easier to have a cigarette and push that problem back down. God understands that.

But if you are doing what will cause you to be set free, speaking the Word, praying in the Holy Ghost, and worshiping God, you are putting yourself on a collision course with deliverance. Your miracle is ahead of you on that path. You begin walking because you have come to know that you are free.

Whether you move an inch, two inches, three inches, or two feet on your freedom line, if you do every day what the Word says belongs to free people, eventually you will intercept your miracle.

Here is the grace of God: as long as you are doing what you are supposed to do every day, His grace works with you back there as though you did not have the problem.

Romans 8:10 says:

"And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin;
but the Spirit is life because of righteousness."

If Christ is in you, the body has been declared dead as far as sin is concerned. It does not have the power to reign over the new nature anymore. It may try, because you do not yet have a glorified body, but the promise is here: the body has lost its hold.

Your human spirit is life because of righteousness. It has entered into the God-kind of life. The power plant has changed. Your new nature freed you from sin, and the body has been declared dead because of it.

Every time sin raises its head, that new life in your spirit has more power than what your body is generating. Your mind can go with your new nature, and you can walk out of sin instead of into it.

When you fast, it has everything to do with this verse. Your body has been given a positional truth by your new nature: dead because you are waiting on a glorified body. While you are waiting on that body, this present body has a positional truth to uphold.

Praying in the Holy Ghost enforces the position your spirit has been declared in. Fasting enforces the position your body has been declared in, as far as its ascendancy over your spirit is concerned. If your body has been giving you trouble, add fasting. It executes that positional truth and breaks the dominance your flesh has over your spirit.

Fasting does not move God. It moves you.

God is not the One holding back. He spared not His own Son. Will He not with Him freely give you all things? He wants to heal you, save you, and save everyone around you more than you do.

Some people act as though God is suddenly going to start moving because He just decided to. They talk about Jubilee as if God will now begin saving relatives and changing things while the church stays in the same failure it has been in for years.

When did we enter Jubilee? When Jesus sat down at the right hand of the Father and gave the church power to set captives free. We have been in it ever since.

If God could have saved your relatives apart from the gospel and the authority He gave the church, He would have done it in the last generation. He did not go into the Dark Ages because He needed rest. He left this gospel with us.

When Jesus said, "It is finished," He got over to every child of God everything He could possibly get over in every generation and every decade to reach the person next to him. It was never God withholding. He is the One who spared not His own Son.

The frightening thought is not that the devil will oppose you when you start doing something for God. Of course he will. The frightening thought is that your next five years could look exactly like your last five if nobody starts talking about what God actually gave you.

Romans 8:10-11 says:

"And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin;
but the Spirit is life because of righteousness.
But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you,
he that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by his Spirit
that dwelleth in you."

Verse 11 explains verse 10. If Christ is in you, the body is dead because of sin. Why? Because the spirit has come to life because of righteousness.

The same spirit that raised Christ from the dead also quickens your mortal body. That born-again spirit, that same life which quickened Jesus from death to life and quickened you from death to life, supplies the life needed to enforce the body's declared position: dead to sin.

That is why the next verse says:

"Therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh, to live after the flesh."

You are no longer in debt to the flesh. The new nature canceled the flesh's debt. It cannot declare war against your mind and force you into sin anymore, because the same spirit that raised Jesus from the dead raised you.

The spirit that is of Him is the spirit that is of God and of Christ. As God had life within Himself, He gave to the Son to have life within Himself. Then Jesus gave to your humanity, to your spirit, to have life within itself.

That is what John 1 is about:

"In him was life; and the life was the light of men."

The whole world lay in darkness. Millions of people were on the earth, but not one spiritually alive man was on the planet. Suddenly one candle was burning in all that darkness, one spiritually alive Man standing on the face of the earth, and His name was Jesus.

In Him was life, and that life was my light. Soon the same light that lit Him lit me. Now there are millions of candles burning because the life that was in Him is now my light.

Romans 6 helps explain Romans 8:11. Paul begins:

"What shall we say then?
Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?
God forbid. How shall we, that are dead to sin, live any longer therein?"

When Paul says, "God forbid," that is very strong language. He is drawing a conclusion from Romans 5, where he said:

"Moreover the law entered, that the offence might abound.

But where sin abounded, grace did much more abound."

The law entered so the offense might abound. God gave spiritually dead men the Ten Commandments knowing they could not keep them. Paul said he would not have known sin except the law said, "Thou shalt not covet."

In Galatians, Paul asks what purpose the law served. It was added because of transgressions until the Seed should come. In that context, he is also talking about ordinances, sacrifices, and the Levitical priesthood. Because they were transgressors and could not obey God, animals were slaughtered instead of men facing the death penalty.

At Solomon's dedication of the temple, thousands upon thousands of animals were sacrificed, with blood everywhere, and it still could not purge the conscience from sin.

So Paul asks, "Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?" Then he answers, "God forbid. How shall we, that are dead to sin, live any longer therein?"

Romans 5:7-10 says:

"For scarcely for a righteous man will one die:

yet peradventure for a good man some would even dare to die.

But God commendeth his love toward us,

in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

Much more then, being now justified by his blood,

we shall be saved from wrath through him.

For if, when we were enemies, we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son,

much more, being reconciled, we shall be saved by his life."

That is the difference between mercy and grace. While we were yet sinners, Christ died for us. That was mercy. We were outside the promises and had nothing to approach God with, yet He commended His love toward us.

Grace takes the one who accepted mercy, adopts him into the family, calls him a son, clothes him with righteousness, gives him authority, and gives him an inheritance forever.

I used to have a covenant, but Abraham's covenant was fulfilled. Now I am a son. My children do not approach me with a contract to raid the refrigerator. They do not quote anything. They just know, "I am your son," and they go get it.

If God reconciled us when we were enemies, what is He going to hold back now that we are reconciled? We are saved by His life. In Him was life, and the life was the light of men.

Romans 6:3-5 says:

"Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death?

Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death:

that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father,
even so we also should walk in newness of life.

For if we have been planted together in the likeness of his death,
we shall be also in the likeness of his resurrection."

The whole world was in death, and the life of God was in this one Man. In Him was life. He was the first Man to be spiritually alive. Then, by an act of mercy, He died for the whole world and took our sins.

The moment you accept what He did, you are baptized into His death. He paid the penalty of sin for you so that you can be resurrected into His life.

If we have been planted together in the likeness of His death, we shall also be in the likeness of His resurrection. No wonder Romans 8 says, "If Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin, but the spirit is life because of righteousness."

Romans 6:6 says:

"Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him,
that the body of sin might be destroyed,
that henceforth we should not serve sin."

We say, "My old man is dead," but what are we talking about? Galatians says:

"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live;
yet not I, but Christ liveth in me."

The penalty for sin was fulfilled in Jesus as my Substitute. I was baptized into that death. I have been crucified with Him. Yet I live, but it is no longer I in the old sense, because the old man is dead. The old man was destroyed and left behind.

The life I now live in this flesh, before it is glorified, I live by the Son of God. He empowers me to live in this body free from sin.

Romans 6 says our old man was crucified with Him so that the body of sin might be destroyed. The word "destroyed" is strong. The old man is not merely weakened. He is destroyed.

So who was the old man? It was not your physical body. The old man that was crucified with Christ was the old nature that once resided in your spirit. That old nature was the old man.

The embodiment, or encasement, of sin was destroyed. Whatever part of me housed the old nature was obliterated. It is not in me anymore. My new nature is in me now.

That is why sin shall not have dominion over you. You are not under the law anymore. You are under grace. The body of sin was destroyed because the old man was crucified with Christ.

The same Spirit of Christ that raised Christ from the dead, the same life the Father quickened Jesus with, raised me from death to life. It quickens my mortal body and cancels the debt of sin. I am no longer in debt to walk after the flesh.

The old man was destroyed, and the new nature is in me. That is what the Holy Ghost gets behind. He will conquer your soul with it.

When the Holy Ghost and the new nature conquer your soul, God wants the world. He says, "Now the whole world is in darkness, and now that your soul is being conquered, there is nothing this world has that is stronger than you. Go get them. I want the world saved, and I want you to go do it."

You may say, "I do not have enough money."

He says, "I bore your poverty. I want the world. I want you to go do it."

You may say, "Have You seen my checkbook lately?"

He keeps treating you as though what He said is the truth.

This is why a person with the worst possible record can be born again on his deathbed and enter heaven. You may say, "That is not fair."

But heaven's record says that man paid the penalty for his sins when he accepted Christ and was baptized into His death. Jesus suffered the penalty of sin for every person who receives Him. It does not matter how strong the sin was. He died for every man.

The old man who committed those things was destroyed. The new man may only be a few moments old, but he has no past and no record. His suffering was laid on Jesus, and he is as free as you are.

The man was destroyed.

Romans 6:7 says:

"For he that is dead is freed from sin."

Whatever remnants are left are tied to this unglorified flesh. One day the trumpet will sound, and that will be over too. Meanwhile, your reward is based on wearing a body from the first Adam while carrying a spirit made alive in Christ and becoming a reconciler on this earth.

Get as many people saved as you can. Your reward is based on how much of that flesh you overcame with what He gave you.

Hallelujah. Vacation is over.